CHOCOLATE PUDDING PIE

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	REST	TOTAL TIME
1 pie at 23 cm, 8 to 10 servings	**20 min for the assembly**	**1 1/2 h chilled to set the pudding, then 1 h chilled to set the cream**	**about 3 h, not counting the shell**

INGREDIENTS

1 batch	Gluten-free crumb crust, 23 cm, baked and cooled
800 g	Chocolate pudding
360 ml	Heavy cream, very cold
2 tsp	Vanilla extract
1 tbsp	Confectioners' sugar
60 g	Bittersweet chocolate, chopped or shaved

METHOD

1. Make the gluten-free crumb crust in a 23 cm pie pan, bake it through and let it cool. See the base.
2. Set the cooled shell where you can reach it before starting the pudding.
3. Make the chocolate pudding to its own recipe and pour it into the shell straight away, as soon as it comes off the heat.
4. Chill the pie until the surface has gone cold and firm, about 1 1/2 hours.
5. Freeze the mixer bowl and whisk — or a medium bowl, if you are whipping by hand — for 5 minutes.
6. Add the cold cream, the vanilla and the confectioners' sugar to the chilled bowl.
7. Whip on medium speed, or hard by hand, until the cream holds peaks somewhere between medium and firm.
8. Spread the cream over the set pudding with an offset or rubber spatula, taking it right out to the crust.
9. Scatter the chopped chocolate or the shavings evenly across the cream.
10. Chill about 1 hour, until the cream has set. Serve the pie cool.

NOTES

> The pie takes 800 g of pudding and a full batch comes to 1.02 kg, so about 220 g is spare.
> The pudding has to go in while it is warm, so the crust must be baked and cooled before you start it.
> Cold, this pudding sets to roughly the texture of pot de crème and holds a spoon upright, which is what makes the pie sliceable rather than spoonable.
> Keeps in the refrigerator up to 4 days.

FILLING

Chocolate Pudding

Makes: 1.02 kg of pudding, 4 to 6 servings / Active Time: 25 min / Rest: chilled until cold and set / Total Time: 25 min plus chilling

INGREDIENTS

420 ml	Whole milk
150 ml	Heavy cream
30 g	Cornstarch
150 g	Sugar
15 g	Cocoa powder
3	Eggs, large
1/4 tsp	Salt
70 g	Bittersweet chocolate, chopped coarse

METHOD

1. Set a fine-mesh sieve over a large heatproof container and leave it standing ready.
2. Pour the milk and the cream into a medium saucepan with a heavy base. Bring them up to just short of a boil.
3. While the dairy heats, stir the cornstarch and sugar together in a mixing bowl, sift the cocoa powder over them, and whisk until the powder is evenly worked through.
4. Beat the eggs with the salt in a second bowl, tip them into the cocoa and sugar, and whisk to a smooth batter.
5. Pour roughly half the hot dairy into the egg mixture in a thin stream, whisking without pause the whole time.
6. Return the loosened egg mixture to the pan holding the remaining dairy. Cook over medium heat, whisking without stopping, until it has visibly thickened and reads 208F [98C] on a thermometer. Expect 5 to 7 minutes, longer if the eggs went in straight from the fridge.

7. Empty the pan through the sieve immediately.
8. Scatter the chopped chocolate over the hot custard and leave it to melt in the residual heat.
9. Once the chocolate has gone, run an immersion blender through the pudding for 5 full minutes, until not a lump is left. Stop as needed and scrape the sides of the container down with a rubber spatula.
10. A countertop blender in small batches does the same job, as does a whisk and patience. The mixture is near boiling, so handle it carefully either way.

NOTES

This is pastry cream in all but name. The thick set comes from the weight of chocolate stirred in at the end, which firms the custard as it cools, rather than from extra starch.
Adding hot liquid to eggs is tempering. Pour slowly or the eggs cook into threads instead of thickening.
Chase the thermometer, not the look. 208F [98C] is what gelatinises the cornstarch fully, and a custard that merely seems thick will loosen as it sits.
The 5 minutes of blending is what gives the texture. Cut it short and you can feel the grain.
Covered well, it keeps 4 days in the fridge. Eat it with unsweetened cream whipped to soft peaks, or use it to fill the chocolate pudding pie.

BASE

Gluten-Free Crumb Crust

Makes: 1 pie shell at 23 cm, or 1 cheesecake base at 25 cm / Active Time: 10 min / Total Time: about 30 min plus cooling / Oven: 350F / 180C for 5 to 10 min

INGREDIENTS

150 g	Oat digestive biscuits, baked and cooled
4 tbsp	Unsalted butter, melted
1 tbsp + 2 tsp	Brown sugar
1/2 tsp	Salt
1 tsp	Cinnamon, optional

METHOD

1. Bake a batch of oat digestive biscuits ahead and let them cool completely.
2. Heat the oven to 350F.
3. Grind the biscuits to a fine crumb in a food processor, about 30 seconds.
4. Pour the melted butter over the crumbs in an even stream, then add the brown sugar, the salt and the cinnamon if you are using it.
5. Run the processor about 10 seconds more. Stop once a handful of the mixture clumps when you squeeze it in your palm.
6. Tip the crumbs into a pie pan or a springform and press them evenly across the bottom and up the sides.
7. Pack them down firmly with the flat base of a cup.
8. Bake 5 to 10 minutes, until golden brown.
9. Cool the shell completely before any filling goes in.

NOTES

150 g of biscuit works out to roughly 10 of them.
Butter, sugar, salt and cinnamon are all given by volume, with no weights alongside.
The crust is gluten-free because the biscuits are. They are built on rolled oats and oat flour with no wheat, so use certified oats if that matters.
The squeeze test in step 5 is the one that decides the outcome. Crumbs that will not clump bake into a shell that collapses when you cut it.

BASE

Oat Digestive Biscuits

Makes: 24 cookies / Active Time: 25 min / Total Time: about 45 min / Oven: 350F / 180C for 14 min

INGREDIENTS

45 ml	Milk
1 tsp	Molasses
300 g	Rolled oats
80 g	Oat flour
70 g	Dark brown sugar

1 tsp	Salt
1/2 tsp	Baking soda
170 g	Unsalted butter, cold

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F. Line a baking sheet with parchment or a nonstick liner.
2. Stir the milk and molasses together in a small bowl.
3. Cut the butter into 6 mm cubes.
4. In a food processor, grind the rolled oats to a fine meal. Follow with the oat flour, then the brown sugar, the salt and the baking soda, and run it until the mix looks even. Drop in the butter and process to a sandy texture. Pour in the milk and molasses and process just until the dough starts pulling together.
5. By hand, grind the oats fine in a spice grinder or blender. Tip them into a large bowl, add the oat flour, then the brown sugar, the salt and the baking soda, and whisk it all even. Rub the butter in with your fingers until the mixture is sandy. Add the milk and molasses and bring it together with a spatula, stopping as soon as it starts to hold.
6. Turn the dough onto a work surface and knead it a few times into one cohesive mass.
7. Take a tablespoon of dough at a time, roll it into a ball between your palms, and press it flat on the lined sheet. Each disc should end up about 6 mm thick.
8. Bake 7 minutes, turn the sheet around, and bake 7 minutes more, until the bottoms and the edges are golden brown.
9. Let them sit on the sheet 5 minutes, then move them to a wire rack.
10. Keep them in an airtight container at room temperature, where they hold a week.

NOTES

Nothing in the dough is wheat. The structure comes from ground rolled oats plus oat flour, so these are gluten-free if the oats are certified.
A tablespoon of dough per biscuit is what lands the yield at 24. Bigger discs will not bake through in 14 minutes.
The butter goes in cold and is cut or rubbed only to a sandy stage, which is what keeps the texture flaky rather than solid.
300 g of rolled oats against 70 g of sugar puts these on the savory side of a sweet biscuit, and the teaspoon of salt is deliberate.
About 10 of them, 150 g, crumble into a 23 cm gluten-free pie shell or a 25 cm cheesecake base.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____ RATING ____ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

NOTES _____

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